

How Task Analysis Can Help Autistic and ADHD Individuals

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I was working with a client one day who told me she needed help with time management. She said she had no idea how long things would take, and she was missing deadlines at work. To begin developing her sense of time, we took a common chore she needed to do around her apartment (the dishes) and broke it down into a step-by-step process.

Task: Doing the Dishes

Step	Estimated Time	Actual Time
Collect dishes from throughout the apartment and bring them to the kitchen		
Check the dishwasher to see if it's empty		
Unload the dishwasher if there are dishes		
Rinse dishes and load them into the dishwasher		
Hand wash the remaining dishes and leave to dry		

During the week, she was to estimate how long it would take to do each step before she did the dishes and then record how long each step actually took. She came back to coaching the following week with a huge breakthrough. She said, “I’ve had this problem for years, and no one has been able to help me figure out what it is! It’s not that I have trouble with time management. It’s that I can’t figure out what the first step is!”

Quick Summary

- **Task analysis** is a practical way to break a complex goal into smaller, clear, doable steps so you can get started and keep moving.
- Many autistic and ADHD individuals aren’t struggling with “motivation” so much as **figuring out the first step** (and the steps that follow).
- A good task analysis includes defining the goal, identifying the component steps, sequencing them, and noting tools, skills, and common obstacles.
- Task analysis can strengthen **executive functioning skills** like planning, organizing, sequencing, and estimating time.
- The “right” level of detail matters: too much can feel overwhelming, too little can leave you stuck.
- Tools like [goblin.tools](#) (**Magic ToDo**) can suggest steps when you’re frozen and don’t know where to begin.



By breaking this common household chore of doing the dishes down into steps, she realized that *this* was what she was actually struggling with – not knowing how to break a bigger goal into achievable steps, which kept her from taking the *first* step.

Because this process was all internal, from the outside it looked like laziness, lack of motivation, lack of caring, and an inability to manage her time, but nothing could be further from the truth. Unfortunately, over time, neurodivergent individuals tend to internalize these messages and begin to believe they are lazy or even dumb when they struggle with these things.

What is Task Analysis?

Navigating the world can present many challenges for neurodivergent individuals. Among these challenges are completing tasks that may seem easy to others looking in, but for a neurodivergent individual, from the inside the task may seem insurmountable. Enter task analysis. Task analysis has the power to transform seemingly impossible tasks into achievable goals. But what is task analysis, and how does it connect with the needs of neurodivergent individuals?

Very simply, task analysis is the process of breaking down complex activities into smaller, more manageable steps, and creating a step-by-step sequence to accomplishing a goal. This method can help neurodivergent individuals learn new skills or provide clarity on how bigger tasks can be accomplished. It can be a catalyst for greater independence by improving confidence and just helping to get things done.

How Do You Do a Task Analysis?

The goal of a task analysis is to break a goal (or chore or project) into smaller steps where each step is completely achievable by the person performing the task. Each step is not too big, not too small – it should be just right. This methodical breakdown allows individuals to understand and execute unfamiliar complex activities with much greater ease.

The steps listed below are very detailed to cover a broad array of complex goals involving more than one person, such as a project you might be tasked with at work. Not every step is needed for every goal you analyze, though. If the step does not make sense for your particular goal, just skip it!

The Steps for Task Analysis

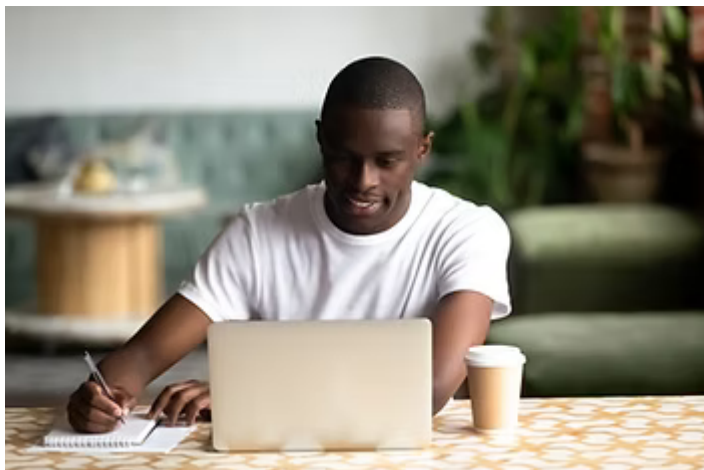
1. Define the Goal

Clearly define the goal you're analyzing. You need to start with the end in mind and be clear about what the outcome looks like. This part of the analysis is the foundation for everything that follows.

2. Identify the Task Components

Break down the task into smaller, manageable steps. This breakdown transforms complex activities into a series of achievable actions. Such an approach simplifies execution and enhances understanding of the task's steps.

3. Gather Information



If the task is particularly complex, you may want to collect detailed information about it. This can involve observing someone performing the task, interviewing experts or individuals who regularly perform the task, and reviewing existing documentation related to the task. Your collected data helps provide a more nuanced understanding of the task.

4. Sequence the Steps

Organize the identified steps in the order they need to be performed. Understanding the order and relationships between steps matters for efficient task completion. This organization is part of the magic in making it easier to execute.

5. Analyze Task Steps

For every step, assess the required actions, necessary tools or resources, and skills or knowledge needed. Additionally, try to anticipate potential challenges or difficulties that could emerge. Identify any dependencies that could impact being able to move forward at a certain step. This part of the analysis ensures preparedness and efficiency in tackling each part of the task so you don't get stuck on any one step.

6. Identify Variabilities

Recognize any variations in how the task might be performed under different conditions or by different individuals with different needs. Consider the adaptability needed for performing the task across various environments or situations. This ensures the task analysis is applicable to diverse contexts.

7. Evaluate Safety Considerations



If there is a potential for safety issues with this task, evaluate potential risks tied to the task or individual steps and come up with a plan for mitigating the risks. Identifying these issues up front minimizes potential problems and ensures safer task execution.

8. Document and Review

Document the findings from the task analysis, including the detailed steps, required resources, skills needed, and any identified risks. Share this documentation with others involved in the task to get their input. This collaborative review ensures you don't miss anything.

9. Develop Training and Support Materials

Based on the task analysis, create training materials or guides to support individuals in learning and performing the task effectively. These resources are designed to facilitate effective and efficient learning and task execution. ***If the goal is relatively simple, a simple checklist of steps is all you need!***

Benefits of Task Analysis for Neurodivergent Individuals

Task analysis can enhance the learning and quality of life of neurodivergent individuals. The structured nature of task analysis, with its clear, step-by-step breakdown, aligns well with the needs of many neurodivergent individuals. Below are some key benefits of integrating task analysis into your life.

Enhances Learning and Comprehension

Many neurodivergent individuals benefit from clear, structured information. Task analysis simplifies complex tasks by breaking them down into sequential steps. This simplification enhances understanding and successful execution.

Promotes Independence



Task analysis offers a clear roadmap for completing tasks, which promotes independence among neurodivergent individuals by reducing the need for assistance. This autonomy can enhance their confidence and self-reliance. Such empowerment is important for personal development and daily life management.

Supports Executive Functioning

Neurodivergent individuals often face difficulties with executive functions like planning and organizing. Task analysis helps by offering a structured plan and clear sequence for tasks they need to complete frequently that they struggle with.

Improves Skill Acquisition

Task analysis is a valuable tool for teaching new skills. By focusing on one step at a time, neurodivergent individuals can gradually learn and master each part of a task without becoming overwhelmed. They can also work from the final checklist and function more independently with less perceived effort on their part.

Customizes Learning

Task analysis allows for tasks to be tailored to an individual's specific needs, strengths, and learning style. This personalized method is particularly advantageous for neurodivergent individuals as it caters to their distinct information processing and learning preferences. Tailoring tasks in this way enhances engagement and effectiveness.

Considerations for Task Analysis

While task analysis is a powerful tool for supporting neurodivergent individuals, its implementation comes with its own set of challenges and considerations. To ensure its effectiveness, it's important to navigate these potential obstacles thoughtfully and proactively.

Task Granularity

Finding the right level of detail in task analysis may involve some experimentation. Having too much detail may create a sense of overwhelm when you see how many steps there are. Having not enough detail means you may get stuck and not be able to move forward if you don't know how to accomplish one of the steps.

One fun tool you can experiment with is called goblin.tools. It's available as a website (free) and a phone app (\$1.99). You just describe what you are trying to accomplish and the level of detail you want. It will provide a list of steps and you can even ask it to estimate the amount of time each step will take. If any individual step is too big, you can ask it to break that one step down further. It's quite fun.

As an example, I asked it to break down the steps required in applying to college. Below is what it produced. If I were actually applying to colleges, and I didn't know how to get started with the first step of researching colleges, I could simply click on the magic wand, and it would break just that one step down further for me.

Magic ToDo

[Help ?](#)

Breaking things down so you don't

Add new item...

☐ apply to college
147 days and 2 hours

☐ Research and identify potential colleges
28 days

☐ Gather all necessary application materials
14 days

☐ Fill out applications for chosen colleges
14 days

☐ Write personal statements or essays
28 days

☐ Request letters of recommendation
21 days

☐ Submit required test scores
14 days

☐ Pay application fees
2 hours

☐ Follow up on application status
14 days

☐ Review and respond to any admission decisions
14 days

Sync

[Goblin.tools](#) is not perfect, but if you're stuck, it may help you get unstuck by suggesting the next best step!

Written Guides

The final output of the task analysis is a guide or checklist that can be used to perform the steps needed to achieve the goal. I have created a task analysis checklist you can [download for free](#) that has an example broken down for you (getting out the door on time in the morning), plus there is a blank page you can use to create your own checklists. Have fun with the reward you give yourself at the end!

Final Thoughts

Individuals with autism and ADHD are often perceived as lazy or unmotivated when in reality, the problem may simply be an inability to break bigger tasks down into smaller steps to figure out what the first step is.

Task analysis is a valuable tool that can significantly help neurodivergent individuals manage their tasks better. By breaking down bigger tasks into smaller, manageable steps, and having a checklist to refer to, individuals can overcome the challenge of not knowing where to start or how to proceed with complex activities. Task analysis can also demystify the learning process by making complex new skills accessible and function as a reminder of how to do something the next time it needs to be done.

Task analysis can not only improve time management and organizational skills but also boost an individual's confidence

and independence. The final output of task analysis, with its clear step-by-step instructions, can help empower neurodivergent individuals to accomplish their goals with greater ease and help them live their best lives.

Key Takeaways

- If you regularly feel stuck, consider that the problem may be **task initiation and sequencing**, not laziness or lack of care.
- Turning one big task into a **step-by-step checklist** can reduce overwhelm and make follow-through more likely.
- Task analysis supports independence because it creates a repeatable plan you can reuse next time.
- When you're learning something new, focus on **one step at a time** and adjust the step size until each step feels truly doable.
- If time is part of the problem, try estimating time per step and then tracking actual time to improve accuracy over time (and reduce deadline surprises).

FAQs About How Task Analysis Can Help Autistic and ADHD Individuals

What is task analysis, in simple terms?

Task analysis is the process of breaking a task (or goal) into smaller steps and putting those steps in the order they need to happen. The end result is usually a checklist or written guide you can follow.

How do I know if my steps are too detailed or not detailed enough?

If you look at the list and feel immediate overwhelm, your steps may be too detailed (or too many steps are visible at once). If you get stuck on a step because you don't know what to do next, your steps probably aren't detailed enough. Adjust until each step feels clearly doable.

How does task analysis help with executive functioning?

Executive functioning includes skills like planning, organizing, sequencing, starting tasks, shifting between steps, and estimating time. Task analysis reduces the "mental load" by putting the plan outside your brain, in a clear sequence you can follow.

Is task analysis only for "big" goals?

No. It can help with everyday tasks (like dishes, laundry, email, showers, getting out the door) and also with larger projects (school, work deadlines, moving, applying for programs). Smaller tasks are often the best place to practice because you can test and refine your steps quickly.

What if I still can't start, even with a checklist?

That's common. Try making the first step smaller until it feels truly easy (for example, "stand up," "open laptop," or "put dishes in one place"). You can also add supports like a timer, a reminder, or a short "reset" break. For ADHD specifically, breaking tasks into shorter steps is a widely recommended strategy.

Ready to get unstuck? If you're an autistic or ADHD adult who wants clearer steps for follow-through, or a parent of a neurodivergent teen or young adult who wants to support independence without power struggles using the SBN™ parenting framework

About the Author

Patty Laushman is the founder and head coach of Thrive Autism Coaching. An expert in the transition to adulthood for autistic emerging adults, she coaches parents in applying her SBN™ parenting framework to strengthen relationships and foster self-sufficiency through her [Parenting for Independence](#) program. Patty's work is rooted in a neurodiversity-

affirming, strengths-based approach that empowers both parents and autistic adults to thrive. She is also the author of the groundbreaking book, [Parenting for Independence: Overcoming Failure to Launch in Autistic Emerging Adults](#).